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More the merrier!! Understanding the effect of available content choices over willingness to pay for over-the-top subscriptions

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Abstract

Around the globe, the trend of cutting cable cords in favor of over-the-top media platforms has been rising tremendously. Further, the influx of different content is disrupting media consumption behavior. Underpinning the choice theory, this study investigates the effect of the availability of content choices on over-the-top platforms on users' subscription intention. Insights from the triangulation of marketplace evidence and interviews reveal that the availability of content choices leads to the willingness to pay for the content, which further leads to the subscription intention. The conceptual framework suggests that content affinity, reviews, and recommendations play a moderating role in suggested relationships. The three experimental studies validate that the role of content choices on subscription intention is mediated by the higher willingness to pay for the content only in the absence of negative platform-related reviews and recommendations. Further, this study presents content strategies and suggested matrices for practitioners and paves the way for academicians to explore digital adoptions using choice theory for future research.

KEYWORDS

choice theory, content affinity, content choices, Hayes process, over-the-top, reviews and recommendations, subscription intention, willingness to pay

1 | INTRODUCTION

In an era marked by the proliferation of new-age technologies and the omnipresence of internet-enabled devices, content creators intend to captivate and engage audiences through the dynamic fusion of interactive services and video content. Drawing upon this technological disruption, the advent of multiple digital devices, such as smartphones, TVs, and tablets, are equipped with AI-enabled innovative platforms providing interactive content, such as Minecraft (with interactive features) on Netflix (a streaming video platform). This streaming video media, commonly referred to as over-the-top content, has revolutionized how individuals watch movies, series, live events, and sports, as it liberates viewers from the constraints of downloading content and ushers them into a realm of immersive, on-demand entertainment experiences (Burroughs & Rugg, 2014; Feit et al., 2013). The growing smartphone and smart TV ownership strongly correlate with the growing demand for content consumption worldwide (Feit et al., 2013). Further, content consumption has witnessed a seismic shift as individuals sought solace and entertainment within the confines of their homes during the pandemic. The demand for convenient and immersive content experiences surged unprecedentedly (Forbes, 2020).[1] In tandem with this societal shift, technologies 4.0 has empowered firms to redefine the boundaries of

[1]https://www.forbes.com/sites/johnkoetsier/2020/09/26/global-online-content-consumption-doubled-in-2020/?sh=5081be792fde

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video consumption, steering it away from traditional experiential viewing, such as the communal act of watching movies in theaters, converging it onto smaller screens (Statista, 2020).[2] Evidencing the resilience and enduring appeal of streaming media, 72% of millennials in the United States (US) and the United Kingdom (UK) affirmed their continued consumption of this burgeoning form of entertainment (Pew Research, 2021).[3] The global streaming services are growing at a CAGR of ~21% Y-o-Y (2021–2028), and in the US alone, however, cable TV subscribers are expected to drop to less than 50 million in 2027 from 60.5 million in 2023 (Statista, 2023).[4]

Media users worldwide are dropping cable subscriptions and subscribing to over-the-top services across developed nations such as the US and Canada, where the combined subscriptions are more than the total population (Forbes, 2023).[5] Gen Z[6] and Gen Alpha[7] prefer over-the-top over cable because they intend to watch global content. The burgeoning fascination of viewers with foreign content, exemplified by the rising popularity of K-pop, K-drama, and Turkish drama, has heralded a paradigm shift in the landscape of video content consumption (Shim, 2006), where these shows are now giving better return on investment (ROI) to the over-the-top platforms. Hence, over-the-top platforms adopted the content strategy of loading their content libraries to present several content choices, which resulted in overwhelming audiences and negatively affecting their intention to pay for platform subscriptions (Matthes et al., 2020). While the existing body of literature has provided valuable insights into various aspects of video content consumption, there remains a dearth of empirical evidence specifically exploring the relationship between content choice availability and its impact on both willingness to pay for content and subscription intention (SI). Hence, in this study, we intend to comprehend the willingness to pay from two different lenses, that is, content perspective and platform perspective.

Furthermore, it is crucial to acknowledge the significant influence of social media and content-related affinity when users contemplate subscribing to over-the-top services (Mulla, 2022). Social media platforms, originally designed for communication purposes, have become deeply intertwined with online content consumption to the extent that recommendations from friends and family now heavily impact over half of the content choices made by individual (Forbes, 2020).[8] However, not much is available to comprehend the role of content affinity and reviews and recommendations (RR) available on social media and/or offline on willingness to pay for the content and platform. Therefore, in this study, we intend to address four research questions—(1) Does the broader availability of content choices have a direct impact on users' SI? (2) To what extent does the willingness to pay for the content indirectly affect availability of content choices and SI? (3) Does content affinity and RR influence the relationship between availability of content choices leading to the user's willingness to pay for the content and SI? (4) What are the implications of these findings for platform managers in terms of content provision and platform subscription strategies?

The paper is divided into four sections. First, we present the understanding of the over-the-top landscape by taking insights from stakeholder interviews, marketplace evidence and literature review. Then, we establish and propose a conceptual framework suggesting the relationship between availability of content choices, willingness to pay for the content and SI and the moderators that affect these relationships. Further, we empirically test the hypothesis employing three experiment studies (study 1, study 2, and study 3) and discuss how academicians and practitioners can implement the suggested insights. Finally, we conclude the study by stating the limitations and future directions.

1.1 | Research motivation: Understanding the over-the-top platform landscape

1.1.1 | In-depth interviews

To comprehend the underlying phenomenon of the current landscape of over-the-top platforms, we interviewed 18 media professionals and experts across five countries across developed and emerging markets—the US, India, UK, UAE, and Kenya. The interviewees were selected based on their decision-making positions, proficiency in the field, and work experience (>7 years) in the domain of over-the-top, nationally and globally. Each interview lasted about 40–50 min, and we generated 150 pages of transcripts and recordings of 500+ min. The in-depth interviews using semistructured questions were focused on understanding the relevant factors related to over-the-top content choices and factors affecting the willingness to pay for the content and SI for the platform. We also consider the disruption in media consumption in the last 2 years due to the pandemic lockdown. We analyzed the data using the Cohen kappa coefficient and achieved a 0.7 value, showing high agreement measures between two coders. The themes that emerged from the codes and subsequent analysis of the interviews have been verified by the panel of researchers with two doctoral scholars, two research executives, and two professors.

The culmination of interviews directed us to the current over-the-top environment, where (1) the demand for content is still higher than the supply of favorable content; (2) the user cannot settle with the currently available options of the content library (multiple genres) as opposed to old media, that is, television; (3) in parallel lines, the adoption of local content by global audiences having high video quality and cultural content is highly preferred due to the relatability of the content; (4) recommendations and series-based affinity are triggers to subscribe to the global and local level content; (5) the positive experience of viewing the content on the given platform converts into subscriptions. Table 1 provides further details and concerns extracted from the interviews.

Next, we collected insights from the marketplace to evaluate the real-time situation in practice.

[2] https://www.statista.com/statistics/947757/theaters-streaming-watching-movies/
[3] https://www.pewresearch.org/internet/2021/04/07/social-media-use-in-2021
[4] https://www.statista.com/statistics/947757/theaters-streaming-watching-movies/
[5] https://www.forbes.com/sites/tonifitzgerald/2023/01/27/surprise-more-and-more-people-are-cutting-their-streaming-tv-services/
[6] Generation Z is the demographic born in the late 1990s or early 2000s.
[7] Generation Alpha is the demographics born in early to mid 2010s.
[8] https://www.forbes.com/sites/forbestechcouncil/2020/09/09/ott-technology-censorship-and-the-future/

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TABLE 1 Interview insights from the industry experts.

Firms	No of interviewees (managers and experts)	Data collection period	Interview insights
Netflix	6	January 2021 to March 2021	• A rich content library with many content choices is the primary feature and tracking content affinity across genres by demography/geography is the key. • The platform adopts a marketing strategy of pushing social media content such as memes. • The platform does consider positive comments about the platform experience. It promotes positive reviews on cross-media platforms like TV to create buzz about the shows.
Amazon Prime Video	5	March 2021 to April 2021	• The platform employees need enriching content choices for the prime users to compete with global platforms. • The platform considers online reviews and keeps up the positive reviews and recommendations.
Disney+	4	May 2021	• Based on their internal analysis of the content library, the platform always strives to launch content choices of high affinity. • The platform tries to maintain positive reviews for its list of content across social media platforms.
Discovery+	3	May 2021	• The platform is trying to replicate its success on the TV channel "Discovery," launching content choices of high affinity. • We are using positive reviews published across social media for the content broadcasted on TV to launch the platform.

1.1.2 | Marketplace evidence

The marketplace evidence is dotted with inductive insights from popular press articles, industry reports, video interviews, magazines, blogs, and conference discussions. Some insights are as follows: First, content quality and personalization needs among audiences drive the demand for over-the-top platforms. For instance, a US-based over-the-top platform, Disney Plus, offers in-house produced content across the globe as well as clubs the entire content library comprising old shows and movies with a modern touch (such as Cinderella, Bob The Builder, Power Puff Girls) under one platform (Daniel, 2021). This amalgamation of a variety of content grabbed global millennial users' attention to live through nostalgia during the pandemic and post-pandemic time, bringing emotional connectivity and relatability into action (Daniel, 2021). Second, the global users' consumption of subscription-based entertainment services passed the one billion mark,[9] and the users still have a rationally driven notional value for watching shows on television or sticking to a genre. Third, global over-the-top platforms use behavioral analytics to update their recommendation algorithm, as they find RR critical for their business. Fourth, the over-the-top platforms can easily stream content across multiple regions as the internet connects the world, unlike cable channels, which must take uplink and downlink permissions for respective geography. For instance, A new Korean series, "Squid Games," on Netflix added 4.4 million new global subscribers to the platform.[10] These content-related dynamics of over-the-top platforms help us understand the importance of innovative content creation, quality, and myriad options.

After getting insights from interviews and marketplace evidence, we plunge into the literature to further explore the gap and relevant theoretical underpinning.

1.2 | Theoretical underpinning, literature review, and conceptualization

1.2.1 | Conceptual choice theory

The overall ecosystem of video-on-demand over-the-top platforms has been studied in previous research across different angles. Extant studies in the over-the-top segment delineate several linear

[9] https://www.latimes.com/entertainment-arts/business/story/2021-03-18/streaming-milestone-global-subscriptions-passed-1-billion-last-year-mpa-theme-report

[10] https://www.bbc.com/news/business-58976204

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factors for the over-the-top adoption at large, such as content, willingness to pay, and RR (Dasgupta & Grover, 2019; Malewar & Bajaj, 2020; Shin et al., 2016; Sujata et al., 2015). Multiple studies have drawn theoretical foundations such as uses and gratification by Blumler and Katz (1974), and technology adoption theories (such as TAM, UTAUT, UTAUT 2) to conduct empirical studies (Lee & Monsam, 2018; Kim & Kim, 2020).

However, we considered choice theory to postulate the conceptualization for this study, originating from psychology-based control theory (Glasser, 1985), since choice theory (Glasser, 1999) highlights the following propositions with emphasis on the people's choices that guide their life. *First*, the root problem of dissatisfaction is either the perceived wrong choices or the inability to choose out of several available options (Suseno & Nguyen, 2023). In the media context, users with cable services face a similar problem where content is bound by the specific time of television broadcast. On the other hand, streaming services empower individuals to choose their genre of interest without restricting the viewing duration (Jenner, 2018; Wang & Lobato, 2019). Preference for streaming services over cable services is attributed to the availability of content choices at any given time. Although cable services provide an array of channel options to an individual, streaming videos offer the option of binge-watching content of their interest, which does not restrict the experience. Hence, this binge-watching trend drives users' purchase intentions of that media platform (Gilbert, 2019; Matrix, 2014; Menon, 2022). *Second*, the choice theory postulates that every decision perceives the quality place in our minds and whether we are happy and satisfied with our options (Suseno & Nguyen, 2023). For video media consumption, one limitation of cable services is that they do not have control over the quality of content. In contrast, streaming services can analyze the demand instantly and present higher affinity content with a better turnaround time (Yousaf et al., 2021) and mild geographical restrictions. The concept of "content affinity" (a measure of likeability for specific video content) represents differential effects on content consumption. *Third*, the choice theory argues that individual decisions are made by comparing a subset of available options attributes (Johnson et al., 2013). To compare the content across genres/platforms/media services, RR is considered as a tool comprised of collective views of content experts (on social media), peers, and friends on a recommendation site (e.g., IMDb.com, rottentomatoes.com) (Kim et al., 2017; Yousaf et al., 2021). However, RR for the platforms have been searched on forums (e.g., Quora) that indicate what to expect from the platform after its subscription. *Finally*, the choice theory posits that the need gap between what we want and what we are receiving defines the total behavior (Corey & Corey, 2013); this explains the rapid shift to streaming services as it fulfills the current need of the individual (Sanson & Steirer, 2019). Next, based on the insights from the interview, marketplace evidence, and theoretical underpinnings, we explain the conceptual framework for this study.

2 | CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Drawing on the choice theory and the factors emerging from the triangulation approach involving marketplace evidence, interviews, and literature, the availability of content choices leads to a higher willingness to subscribe to the platform. At the same time, managerial interviews and marketplace evidence insights suggested the critical role of relevant content in affecting the willingness to pay for the platform. This study's conceptual framework (Figure 1) showcases the direct and indirect effect (mediated by the willingness to pay for the content) of the availability of content choices on users' SI. Further, based on our triangulation, it is suggested that the availability of content choices leads to SI only when there is more willingness to pay for content. Also, RR for the content and content affinity can significantly affect willingness to pay for the content, leading to SI in the presence of platform-related RR.

2.1 | Availability of content choices

With internet-enabled devices' availability and the prevalence of affordable internet data, internet users inherently seek engaging

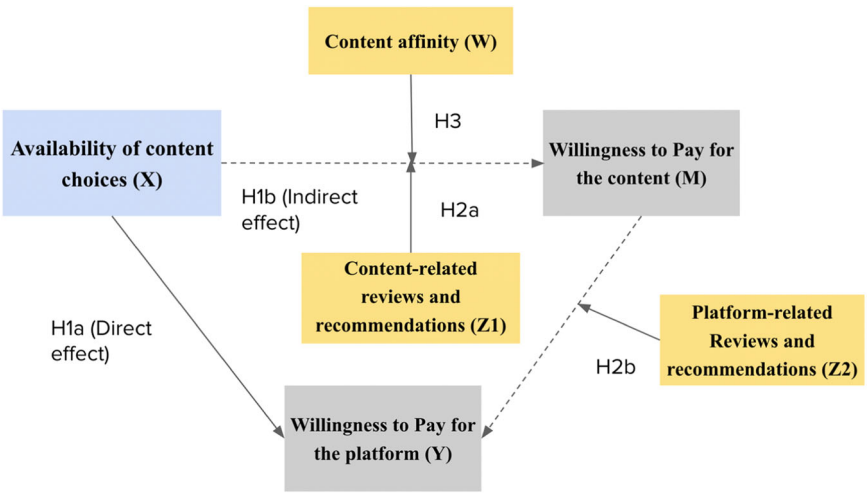


FIGURE 1 Strategic framework for over-the-top platforms leveraging content choices.

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video content. Initial studies collected traces of users' cognitive evolution, shedding light on the influence of second-screen searches (social media) on the valence of the content adoption journey for traditional media (Giglietto & Selva, 2014; Napoli, 2011). Increased interest of users for internet content swamped over-the-top platforms with exclusive content. This surge in exclusive content transformed today's users into more assertive and well-equipped with information than before (Weeds, 2016). The availability of content choices is a critical cue to satisfy the consumers' growing interest in viewing novels and a variety of content (Sung et al., 2022). Hence, it is expected that the more choices given to the users, the more they will be willing to pay for the platform subscription. However, the content emerges as a critical factor in adopting over-the-top platform services. It is observed that if the user is keen on watching a given content and if that is available on a particular over-the-top platform, the user would first be willing to pay for the content. If they have a good experience watching it on a given platform, they would like to subscribe to it in the future. Hence, we suggest that SI can be achieved when a positive willingness exists for the content. Therefore,

Hypothesis 1a. *The availability of content choices directly affects the user's SI.*

Hypothesis 1b. *The availability of content choices indirectly affects the user's SI mediated by the willingness to pay for the content.*

2.2 | The moderating role of RR and content affinity

2.2.1 | Content-related and platform-related RR

Users are widely influenced by reading online *RR*, which leads to the sentimental deviation of perception (Zhao et al., 2019). The validation and social acceptance for belonging to a particular over-the-top video streaming community have curated two paths: physical word-of-mouth and online RR. Insights from our triangulation approach informed two lenses—*first*, content perspective and *second*, platform perspective. Users' need for gratification is attributed to peer recommendations and word of mouth, which pushes users to consume exclusive content on over-the-top platforms (Conway & Rubin, 1991), both online and offline. Interviews insights indicate that many positive stimuli toward over-the-top content consumption come from colleagues, friends, and family. Media gratification mainly depends on and is influenced by another individual's positive psychological stimuli (Conway & Rubin, 1991). Hence, we propose.

Hypothesis 2a. *The content-related RR will moderate the relationship between availability of content choices and willingness to pay for the content.*

Further, new-age technologies enabled ease of use for several online communities within social media platforms for the given over-the-top platform. Streaming service users post their reactions online, driving the urge to follow the platform trend (Kozinet & Patterson, 2017). Such as the "Netflix" community on Facebook, with over 1 lakh followers worldwide, where members post their reviews about over-the-top releases. Previous studies point to the importance of appreciation and usage of digital platforms; willingness-to-pay for the content will be a better predictor and central in the presence of electronic word-of-mouth (Craig et al., 2015; Taneja & Mamoria, 2012). Therefore, we propose.

Hypothesis 2b. *The platform-related RR will moderate the relationship between willingness to pay for the content and SI.*

2.2.2 | Content affinity

Content affinity, the "perceived importance of and attachment to particular media content," is crucial in driving over-the-top adoption (Ji & Wayne Fu, 2013). Content affinity is driven by an array of content-related features and strategies, influencing consumer content choice decisions for various reasons. First, users inherently seek a variety of content covering different genres and the expectations from the quality of content to keep pace with technological advancement. Second, the popularity of vernacular content is increasing due to the introduction of local language into global content. Global users are curious to watch cross-cultural shows (Subramanian et al., 2021) and develop a set of affinity toward the given content. Third, a few over-the-top platforms adopt content-related strategies, such as adding nostalgic content to their over-the-top library. For instance, Amazon Prime added all classic movies in the library instead of investing in exclusive content; the consumption of nostalgic content is supported by recommendation algorithms suggesting similar content. This algorithmic strategy allows platforms to exercise users' search behavior on networking websites or apps and connect with nostalgic emotions. For instance, the addition of old classic movies on Amazon Prime Video or newer regional content that went global, such as Squid Games and Money Heist on Netflix. Finally, the exclusivity of the content is one of the significant forces garnering users' attention toward over-the-top platforms that are weaving customized content for their subscribers (Ishihara & Oki, 2021). These strategies are bound to increase the users' affinity toward the content, sequentially expected to influence the willingness to pay for the content. Therefore, we postulate that.

Hypothesis 3. *The user's affinity toward the content moderates the relationship between availability of content choices and willingness to pay for the content.*

Understanding the interplay of these moderating factors may help the media industry and its managers better comprehend the role of content on SI with an insight into curating the strategies to enhance users' willingness to pay for subscriptions and continuous usage in future.

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Next, we set up the experiments to empirically validate our proposed hypotheses and conceptualization.

3 | EXPERIMENTAL DESIGN

We conducted three experimental studies to empirically validate the identified factors and moderators affecting the users' willingness to pay for content and over-the-top platform subscription. Study 1 presents preliminary evidence that users' SI significantly increases with the increased availability of content choices by the given over-the-top platform mediated by the higher willingness to pay for the content. Study 2 (2a and 2b) demonstrates the moderating effect of content-related RR and content affinity over the willingness to pay for the content and platform-related RR over SI. Study 3 evaluates the effect of content affinity over willingness to pay for the content. We checked the heterogeneity of the variables employing a correlation matrix (refer to Supporting Information: Appendix A). Finally, we conducted path analysis using "Hayes process" (SPSS) to present statistical evidence for the indirect effect of availability of content choices and SI mediated by the willingness to pay for the content, moderated by platform-related RR (as mentioned in Figure 2).

Study 1: The availability of content choices influences users' SI: the mediating effect of willingness to pay for the content (testing H1a and H1b).

The growing business of subscription-based over-the-top platforms is attributed to the availability of many content choices more conveniently than traditional cable services. The objective of Study 1 was to demonstrate the direct and indirect effects of content choices provided by over-the-top platforms on SI.

3.1 | Method

3.1.1 | Pretest

To select the content type for the experiment, we first surveyed 100 millennial participants (age 21–40; male: female 50:50 ratio) to understand the most commonly watched content on the over-the-top platform. Results of the pretest showed that the preferred genre for males is sports and drama genres for females (e.g., presented a list of the genres to choose the top 3 and tag the latest shows they liked the most).

3.1.2 | Design and participants

A one-factor (without genre-content choice: with genre-content choices) between-subject design was employed with 300 millennial participants (age 21–40; male: female 50:50 ratio), out of which 36 failed the manipulation check. The final sample consisted of 264 participants (male—140, female—124), followed by an online questionnaire to measure user's SI using a categorical scale (1: willing to pay for the platform and watch the content, 2: not willing to pay for the platform but can watch the content, and 3: not willing to pay for the platform or content). The participants were presented with two scenarios, one without any choice of genres and the other with a list of genres. In the first scenario (without options), a cricket match/football match (sports genre) and a romantic drama movie trailer (entertainment genre) to be broadcasted on the over-the-top platform were shown. In the second scenario (with options), participants were asked to choose from a list of eight popular genres (drama, comedy, thriller, mystery, action, horror, sports, and romance).

3.1.3 | Procedure and stimuli

Participants were asked whether they were willing to pay for the content and, subsequently, SI for the platform based on a trailer of the show presented to them. A link to a questionnaire was given to them to read the instructions carefully. For the first scenario, male participants viewed the trailer of an India versus Kenya cricket match (Match 01 World T20 Cup—League match) and the National League trailer (Match 20–October 2021). Female participants were shown the trailer of "After We Fell," a romantic movie on Netflix. Upon completion of the experiment, participants responded to demographic-related questions. Finally, participants were asked to indicate the possible storyline of the trailer for attention check.

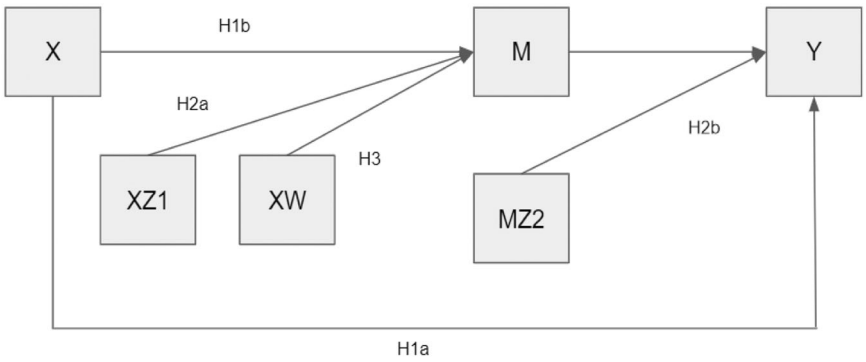


FIGURE 2 Statistical model (Hayes process).

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3.1.4 | Results

The paired *t*-test before and after treatment results shown in Table 2 indicated that there is a significant difference between the responses with willingness to pay for the content and SI ($t = -5.317$, mean = −0.235, SD = 0.718; $p < 0.01$). Later, the ANOVA test showed significant results for the availability of content choices impact on SI in the presence of willingness to pay for the content. However, the results were not significant for the direct impact of the availability of content choices on SI (refer to Table 3).

Next, we check the moderating effect of content-related RR (Positive/Negative/Neutral) and content affinity (High/Moderate/Low) on willingness to pay for the content.

3.2 | The moderating effect of RR and content affinity

Study 2a: The moderating effect of content-related RR on availability of content choices and willingness to pay for the content (testing H2a).

Study 2b: The moderating effect of platform-related RR on willingness to pay for the content and SI (testing H2b).

Studies 2a and 2b aimed to examine the effect of RR further. Study 2a examined the effect of valence for content-related RR on willingness to pay for the content ($WTP_{content}$). In continuity, Study 2b replicates SI. We expected the participants to express their intention to pay different prices for the content and platform subscription. The measures for platform-related RR included 1 item from Bower et al. (2020), 1 item from Higueras-Castillo et al. (2019), 1 item from Yoshida et al. (2015), and the measures for content-related RR included four items from Lim et al. (2012). All scales performed satisfactorily, with a Cronbach alpha of more than 0.7 (refer to Table 4).

3.3 | Method

3.3.1 | Pretest

For selecting the source for RR that users trust the most, we surveyed 100 participants to state the source they refer to the most. IMDb website emerged as the top choice for 79% of the respondents.

3.3.2 | Design and participants

In Study 2, we used a 3 × 2 × 2 matrix between-within-subject design (content-related RR (Positive/Negative/Mixed) for the content/platform × willingness to pay content/SI). In Study 2a, 264 participants were exposed to the reviews' screenshots from the IMDb website, a popular site for RR, followed by the questionnaire to capture the perception of the valence of the reviews (positive, negative, or neutral) and willingness to pay for the content using an interval scale (1—willing to watch the content to 5—not willing to watch the content). Five participants were unable to fill out the questionnaire and, hence, were excluded from the analysis. In Study 2b, the same set of respondents was exposed to reviews related to platform services. Further asked to mark the valence of the reviews (positive, negative, or neutral), fill out a detailed questionnaire on their intention to pay for the platform's subscription, and prompt the reason for choosing the selected content ($WTP_{content}$).

3.3.3 | Procedure and stimuli

We controlled the content-related RR by providing limited information on the upcoming trailer. Later, the RR was added to map the effect of content-related RR on willingness to pay for the content. In continuation, we exposed the participants to platform-related RR of different valences selected randomly to map its effect on the platform's SI. The valence options were three: positive, negative, and mixed. Participants were prompted to mark the perceived valence of the content-related RR to measure any possible change in attitude.

3.3.4 | Results

The paired *t*-test before and after exposing positive content-related RR results in Table 2 indicate a significant difference between the content-related RR and willingness to pay for the content ($t = -18.777$, mean = −0.738, SD = 0.531; $p < 0.01$). Similarly, the paired *t*-test before and after exposing negative content-related RR indicates that there is a significant difference between content-related RR and willingness to pay for the content ($t = 14.033$, mean = 1.185, SD = 0.760; $p < 0.01$). However, the results for mixed reviews were excluded because of the low sample size.

The paired *t*-test before and after exposure to positive platform-related RR results in Table 2 indicated a nonsignificant difference between platform-related RR and the user's SI. However, the paired *t*-test before and after exposure to negative RR results in Table 2 indicates a significant difference between platform-related RR and SI for the platform ($t = -26.203$, mean = −4.8, SD = 1.68; $p < 0.01$).

Study 3: The moderating effect of content affinity on availability of content choices and willingness to pay for the content. (Testing H3)

The objective of study 3 was to examine the effect of content affinity on the availability of content choices and willingness to pay for the content with valence. We expected the participants to express their intention to pay after watching the latest trailer. The measures for content affinity included four items from Wang et al. (2015) and two items from Hu et al. (2017). All scales performed satisfactorily, with a Cronbach alpha of more than 0.7 (refer to Table 4).

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TABLE 2 Hypothesis results (paired *t*-tests).

Hypothesis (study)	Path tested	Particular	Significance level (two-tailed)	Paired *t*-Test result	Descriptive interpretation
Hypothesis 1a and 1b (Study 1)	Direct AOCC => SI	*Hypothesis 1a: AOCC directly affects the SI*	Nonsignificant, $p = 0.6$ ($r = 0.03$)	-	A wide range of content availability leads to the SI in the presence of a higher willingness to pay for content.
	Indirect effect AOCC=> WTP => SI	*Hypothesis 1b: AOCC indirectly affects the SI mediated by the* $WTP_{content}$	Significant, $p < 0.001$ ($r = 0.709$)	$t = -5.317$, mean = −0.235, SD = 0.718	
Hypothesis 2a and 2b (Study 2)	AOCC* $RR_{content}$ (Positive/ Negative)=> $WTP_{content}$	*Hypothesis 2a: The* $RR_{content}$ *will moderate the relationship between AOCC and* $WTP_{content}$	Significant, $p < 0.001$ ($r = 0.655$)	$t = -18.777$, mean = −0.738, SD = 0.531	Positive reviews and recommendations of the available pool of streaming content lead to a positive correlation with the willingness to pay for the content but do not translate to platform
			Not significant, $p = 0.912$ ($r = 0.011$)	-	
	AOCC * $RR_{platform}$ (Positive/ Negative) => SI	*Hypothesis 2b:* $RR_{platform}$ *will moderate the relationship between* $WTP_{content}$ *and SI*	Significant, $p < 0.001$($r = 0.655$)	$t = 14.033$, mean = 1.185, SD = 0.760	Negative reviews and recommendations of the available pool of streaming content lead to a negative correlation with the willingness to pay for content and platform.
			Significant, $p < 0.001$ ($r = 0.72$))	$t = -26.203$, mean = −4.8, SD = 1.68	
Hypothesis 3 (Study 3)	AOCC*CA (High) => WTP	*Hypothesis 3: CA moderates the impact of the AOCC on* $WTP_{content}$	Nonsignificant, $p = 0.064$ ($r = 0.219$)	-	Higher content affinity leads to WTP for the content in all cases; hence, a wide variety of content choices does not impact WTP for the content.
	AOCC*CA (Moderate) => WTP		Significant, $p < 0.001$ ($r = 0.737$)	$t = -5.425$, mean = −0.148, SD = 0.308	Moderate content affinity leads to higher WTP for the content.
	AOCC*CA (Low) => WTP		Significant, $p < 0.001$ ($r = 0.715$)	$t = -8.063$, mean = −0.351, SD = −0.351	Low content affinity in all cases leads to a negative intention for willingness to pay for the content.

Abbreviations: AOCC, availability of content choices; CA, content affinity; $RR_{content}$, content-related reviews and recommendations; $RR_{platform}$, platform-related reviews and recommendations; SD, standard deviation; SI, subscription intention; $WTP_{content}$, willingness to pay for the content.

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3.4 | Method

3.4.1 | Pretest

To identify the content likeability of the selected genre, a study was conducted among 50 participants to group the content affinity into categories high, moderate, and low. They were exposed to the trailers of the content of random genres and asked to group the content as high, moderate, and low. Later, participants filled out the questionnaire to mark the content affinity to validate the responses (likeability toward the preferred content selected out of the previous choice of genre).

3.4.2 | Design and participants

We used a one-factor matrix of the content of Degree (High/Moderate/Low) between-subject design in a field setting. In this study, we randomly divided the participants into two groups (Group 1—Test group, Group 2—Control group) having 132 participants each.

3.4.3 | Procedure and stimuli

The questionnaire is measured using a 5-point Likert scale (1—Loved the content, 5—did not like the content at all). For further analysis, we divided the content affinity into three groups (1 ≤ content affinity < 2 = "Low," 2 ≤ content affinity < 3.5 = "Moderate," 3.5 ≤ content affinity ≤5 = "High").

TABLE 3 ANOVA analysis.

Model	R	Adjusted R square	Std. error of the estimate	df^2	Sig. F change
AOCC—> $WTP_{content}$	0.408[a]	0.166	0.163	263	0
$WTP_{content}$—> SI	0.300[a]	0.09	0.086	263	0
AOCC—>SI	0.034[a]	0.001	−0.003	263	0.6

Abbreviations: AOCC, availability of content choices; SI, subscription intention; $WTP_{content}$, willingness to pay for the content.
[a]Predictors (constant).

3.4.4 | Results

In SPSS, we split the cases based on the content affinity to measure the willingness to pay for the content under each group of $contentaffinity_{Average}$ (High/Moderate/Low). The paired *t*-test for the high-content affinity group shows no significance between the availability of content choices and willingness to pay for the content. This result is attributed to users always paying for high-interest content as the perceived entertainment value is higher than any associated cost. While on the contrary, the paired *t*-test for the moderate and low content affinity groups shows a significant difference between the availability of content choices and willingness to pay for the content ($t = -8.063$, mean = −0.351, SD = −0.351; $p < 0.01$) ($t = -5.425$, mean = −0.148, SD = 0.308; $p < 0.01$) (refer to Table 2).

3.5 | Analysis

Experimental studies were set up to test the proposed hypothesis empirically. We internally validated the findings by examining the generalizability of factors for measuring the willingness to pay for one unit of content and the summation of all content preferences for the SI. In this experiment, the trailers we presented as stimuli were priced INR 150/- (India), $10 (US), and Shilling 1000 (Kenya) at par with the average rate per user, depending on the geography. We considered the factors that would positively impact the willingness to pay for the content and continued intention to consume the content on the given platform. We performed Hayes process analysis on the overall model to validate the effects of each of the parameters on willingness to pay for the content and subsequently for the user's SI (Refer to Table 5).

Concisely, the results indicate a significant impact of the higher number of content choices in streaming platforms on willingness to pay for the content and, subsequently, for the platform. Furthermore, positive content-related RR affects the willingness to pay for the content but do not significantly affect SI. However, negative platform-related RR can significantly affect SI. In the low—moderate content affinity scenario, the availability of content choices significantly impacts willingness to pay for the content and, subsequently, SI. In contrast, negative platform-related RR in case of high content affinity do not affect willingness to pay for the content and continued intention.

TABLE 4 Reliability statistics.

Particulars	Cronbach's Alpha	No. of items	Scale reference
Content affinity	0.786	6	Wang et al. (2015); Hu et al. (2017)
Reviews and recommendations (content and platform)	0.825	7	Bower et al. (2020); Higueras-Castillo et al. (2019); Yoshida et al. (2015) Lim et al. (2012)

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TABLE 5 Path analysis (Hayes process).

Particulars	Hayes process	Valence	R^2	*p* Value	Results
AOCC*CA-> $WTP_{content}$ -> SI	Model 9	High	0.48	0.00	*p* Value (Rsq—0.75, $p < 0.001$) is significant for the AOCC interaction with CA and $RR_{content}$
		Moderate	0.73	0.00	
		Low	0.78	0.00	
AOCC*$RR_{content}$ -> $WTP_{content}$ -> SI	Model 9	Negative	0.84	0.00	
		Neutral	0.89	0.00	
		Positive	0.26	0.00	
AOCC*CA*$RR_{content}$ -> $WTP_{content}$ -> SI		Both Interactions	0.75	0.00	
$WTP_{content}$*$RR_{platform}$ -> SI	Model 2	Negative	0.1	0.02	*p* Value (Rsq—0.10, $p < 0.001$) is significant with the $WTP_{content}$ (along with moderator) leading to SI
		Neutral	0.11	0.07	
		Positive	0.06	0.04	
		Combined interaction	0.1	0	
AOCC*CA ->SI (Direct effect)	Model 2	High	−0.36	0.46	The direct relation between AOCC and SI is not significant
		Moderate	0.65	0.06	
		Low	0.24	0.45	
AOCC*$RR_{platform}$ -> SI (Direct effect)	Model 2	Negative	0.57	0.15	
		Neutral	0.26	0.68	
		Positive	−0.48	0.01	
		Total	−0.24	0.11	

Abbreviations: AOCC, availability of content choices; CA, content affinity; $RR_{content}$, content-related reviews and recommendations; $RR_{platform}$, platform-related reviews and recommendations; SI, subscription intention; $WTP_{content}$, willingness to pay for the content.

3.6 | Discussion

Retention of existing users, acquiring new ones, and engaging them to spend more time browsing and viewing the content has become challenging for over-the-top firms. In this competitive scenario, an over-the-top platform can maintain a return on content investments by extending the quality and differentiating service to loyal users. The current study brings the importance of measuring the performance of factors/moderators or variables that individually or collectively affect content affinity, resulting in a positive impact on SI. The results depict that in the case of high content affinity, users are psychologically biased toward positive recommendations, which collectively increases the probability of a user's SI. However, in the case of moderate content affinity, collective reviews and recommendations (content + platform) play a vital role in deciding SI. In the case of low content affinity, the reviews are mostly perceived as negative owing to the inadequate experience with the content and lead to a low probability of SI.

There are two ways to monetize the content for over-the-top platforms, fee-based (paying a fee to watch the content) and advertisement-based (the content/platform has advertisements). Over-the-top platforms can create monthly subscription packages, keep the content for free with advertising or use both strategies to earn, which may address mass. Hence, subscription-based platforms must choose the right content mix and identify willingness to pay for the content.

4 | IMPLICATIONS

4.1 | Managerial implications

The platforms are thriving with the 5G connection launch and new-age technology infused into the over-the-top platforms. However, in most Asian countries, such as China, the willingness to pay for the platform drastically decreased in the last decade (Kim et al., 2017). Likewise, consumers across the globe seek as much free content as possible. Hence, over-the-top firms must

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understand how consumers choose to pay for content and the platform amidst the available content choices. This study suggests that practitioners from over-the-top firms must critically pay attention to content reviews, recommendations, and content affinity toward the offered content while devising platform subscription strategies. The content ratings should be closely observed and measured to calculate the platform's perception regarding its content library. Such a post-broadcast analysis should be done to take future actions. Over-the-top managers should apprehend decisions before licensing or investing in content; thus, the study curated a matrix for the valence of content-related RR and content affinity among users exhibiting a high willingness to pay (refer to Table 6). Which shows that the percentage of high or moderate affinity content has the maximum share of 79%. A total of 61% of users with high and moderate affinity content perceive the available RR as positive. The table establishes the insight that managers may collect RR for the content from the social domain and categorize their impact based on the users' level of content affinity, leading to higher ROI in terms of subscription and engagement with the platform.

Moreover, the platform's strategies for displaying the relevant content on search and suggesting similar genre content based on past behavior using practical algorithms require appropriate matrices to employ. Hence, based on the study results, we propose an implementable equation (Refer to Equation 1) for the managers to measure the content positioning vis-à-vis competition to identify the SI.

4.2 | SI for the platform

$$\text{Probability of } SI_{platform} = [C_i \times RR_{content} \times CA] \times RR_{platform}, \quad (1)$$

Where $SI_{platform}$ is subscription intention, and C_i is indexed relative rank share of content library (content choices).

TABLE 6 Matrix for valence of content-related reviews and recommendations and content affinity among users exhibiting high willingness to pay.

Content affinity valence	Perceived available reviews and recommendation as positive (%)	Perceived available reviews and recommendation as negative (%)
High content affinity	23	6
Moderate content affinity	38	12
Low content affinity	19	3

Source: The table insights are curated based on data collected from study 2 and study 3 data, Sample size = 169.

The indexed value C will be calculated by giving ranks to the platform based on the number of shows/movies/titles present in the library. Assuming there are 10,000 show titles available across all platforms and platform 1 has a total of 2000 show titles (1200[11] new show titles + 800 old show titles), platform 1 will have indexed rank share of 0.2 (Number of shows for a particular platform/total shows present across platforms).

$RR_{content}$ = Combined sentiment analysis of content-related reviews, recommendations, and ratings for all the content available on the given platform (1–0.1 for positive–negative recommendations, respectively).

$RR_{platform}$ = Combined sentiment analysis of platform-related reviews, recommendations, and rating for the given platform (1–0.1 for positive–negative recommendations, respectively).

CA = Combined degree of content affinity (1–0.1 for content affinity).

We provide over-the-top managers with a tool to help them predict the users' SI. Over-the-top platform managers should strategize while procuring or producing any content, and they can save the cost of content by employing a content strategy that includes segmentation based on content affinity, targeting based on RR, and positioning based on willingness to pay for the content. The content strategy would yield better results by saving the cost of licensing and producing content. Table 7 presents potential segmentation, targeting, and positioning-related matrices managers can use to devise an appropriate content strategy.

4.3 | Academic implications

The study has three main academic contributions. *First*, the experiments have utilized the latest streaming content promotional video; researchers in the future can use the same experimental method to see the impact of other relevant factors, such as privacy concerns, length and quality of the content, popularity of cast and crew, on willingness to pay for content and SI. Since conducting surveys takes time and effort, experiments can be a very effective alternative to validate conceptual models. *Second*, our study employed choice theory, which postulates how the present number of choices affects users' decisions. In the age of a multitude of content creators across social media platforms, the theory can be applied to devise strategic insights for any digital content and contribute to the strategic marketing literature for digital media-related research. The fundamental propositions of the theory discuss how several content choices, when aligned with the cultural, vernacular iterations, and social interaction, affect a user's cognitive decision. By applying overarching choice theory, this study extends the application of the

[11]The definition of new or old shows/titles can be determined or defined by the platform as per their company norms.

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TABLE 7 Strategies and possible inclusion of matrices.

Over-the-stop content matrices	Matrices help in identifying	Content-related matrices are curated based on
Analyzing content library[a]	Segmentation	- Likeability of the genre - Affinity of the cast involved - Impact of content script - Cost of licensing/dubbing - Acceptable duration of the content - Word-of-mouth quotient
Social media performance	Targeting	- Conversions (search to subscription) - The return on their investments of the entire marketing budget - Likes and shares of the snippets across all social media
Content performance	Positioning	- Mapping audience journey within the over-the-top platform - Target audiences' preferences

[a]A content library is a collection of content such as movies and shows.

theory to draw strategic insights. *Finally*, the study employed paired t-tests and the Hayes process to test factors and moderators. The proposed constructs have the potential to enhance the immersive, over-the-top experience and need to explore further their interactions with other related constructs impacting the engaging customer experience. It is essential to grasp its potential as a winning strategy in the market by refining the metric for better measures and standards. The over-the-top industry offers promising research opportunities and hence, should be explored by academicians.

5 | LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

This study considered cross-sectional data; more robust data collected periodically might reveal more interesting insights. The data is not tested for all age groups, as the recent articles show differential trends across Gen Z and older generations. The growth in the consumption of over-the-top was attributed to Covid-19 restrictions worldwide; a longitudinal study employing mixed methods would provide a more profound understanding of the topic in regular times. Moreover, over-the-top audio and gaming are experiencing a differential trend pointed out by many scholars and could be tested using the empirical method. The study conducted for content-related drivers for over-the-top adoption needs to be empirically tested, as several user-related factors, such as convenience and cost, were directed in previous studies. The users often perceive over-the-top platforms as polarizing; researchers can explore the influence of over-the-top in society and what can be done to make over-the-top platforms less divisive. Furthermore, future researchers can examine the role of new-age technologies like VR and AI for innovation and seamless experiences for users. In addition, the study can be extended to explore other moderating factors—firm-related micro factors and country-related factors such as strict government regulations and environmental conditions.

6 | CONCLUSION

In the streaming content era, connecting with the users and maintaining the platform's return on investment is imperative. A wide variety of content choices is pushing SI for streaming platforms. The results show that willingness to pay for high-affinity content is positive, irrespective of negative reviews. However, moderate affinity content is widely affected by content-related RR. Also, low-affinity content will not be viewed in the presence of positive reviews. Moreover, users will refuse to pay for content with low affinity and negative reviews for the platform or content. Keeping track of content performance and its effectiveness for the platform is essential. The study proposed matrices for SI and willingness to pay for the content using content-related factors such as availability of content choices, affinity, and RR. Although higher content affinity will lead to a continued intention to pay for the platform, in case of moderate or low content affinity, negative reviews can seriously degrade the position of the content and further the intention to pay for the platform's subscription. Hence, over-the-top firms are advised to consider and maintain a positive perception of the content among their users.

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CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

ETHICS STATEMENT

The institute committee waives the requirement for approval from participants. However, we got the consent of participants before getting the questionnaire filled out, mentioning that the current research is purely for academic purposes and that no data will be further shared with any entity.

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APPENDIX A

See Table A1

TABLE A1 Correlation matrix.

Correlations		Availability of content choices	Willingness to pay for the content	Moderators—Content affinity	Moderators—content-related reviews and recommendations	Moderators—platform-related reviews and recommendations	Subscription intention
Availability of content choices	Pearson correlation	1	0.408	0.800	0.000	0.000	0.034
	Sig. (two- tailed)		0.000	0.000	0.999	0.998	0.600
WTP for the content	Pearson correlation		1	0.606	0.559	0.551	0.300
	Sig. (two- tailed)			0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Moderators—content affinity	Pearson correlation			1	0.064	0.062	0.041
	Sig. (two tailed)				0.320	0.315	0.525
Moderators—content-related reviews and recommendations	Pearson correlation				1	0.047	0.241
	Sig. (two tailed)					0.622	0.000
Moderators—platform-related reviews and recommendations	Pearson correlation					1	0.241
	Sig. (two tailed)						0.000
Subscription intention	Pearson correlation						1

Note: Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (two tailed).

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